



WORK AND PLAY
Students at the Yale
School of Management

large network stand out.

The diffident Indian with a bit of fear about failure often has a more focused and nuanced approach. Vartika Bansal, AI Ops Partner, Elevation Capital, who studied at Stanford Graduate School of Business, says risk-taking is a key facet. “The real risk is not in failing but in not trying. I realised chasing your wildest dreams and testing your potential is far more rewarding than playing safe and calculating career moves,” she says.

In the life of a student, that eureka moment changes everything. For Ahana Gautam, Founder and CEO of healthy snacking brand Open Secret, it was at Harvard when a case study on PepsiCo got a response from one of her class-

mates on the ethical responsibility of companies. “The time at Harvard was about moving from a pleasure-seeking mindset to creating a meaningful impact,” she says.

One thing led to another, and visiting chains like Whole Foods Market and Trader Joe’s strengthened that resolve. “It convinced me of the potential of my idea in India and a belief in the growing importance of health and fitness,” explains Gautam, who studied chemical engineering at IIT Bombay before heading westwards. In 2019, she set up Open Secret as an “unjunking food option.” The decision to return stemmed from a desire “to build something meaningful despite better opportunities in the US, says Gautam.

Not everyone opts for the traditional two-year degree. Take the case of Rajiv Mehta, General Partner, Athera Venture Partners, who chose to study at INSEAD, being convinced about a one-year programme. “There was the opportunity cost part to it, plus it came with a global and diverse student body,” he says. Before his current assignment, Mehta headed sports company PUMA, followed by stints at apparel and lifestyle companies such as Arvind Ltd and kitchen and home appliances company Stovekraft.

The undergraduate degree does make a difference. In INSEAD, most students, according to Mehta, are engineers. “However, they do not restrict the proportion since this does not create diversity. Being an engineer was a plus, but having peers from other streams helped in the overall learning,” he says. The one-year programme led to more intense networking, he says. “It is counterintuitive. In a short span, and in a high-stress environment, you end up making great friends.”

To Bansal, the fact that Stanford had one of the best engineering schools mattered. “As someone trained in that stream, I valued its analytical rigour, emphasis on problem-solving and culture of innovation. The school’s ability to blend technical excellence with business acumen aligned perfectly with the kind of growth I was seeking,” she says. Besides, the opportunities to take classes across the schools were a huge plus.

Tewari emphasises Harvard’s famed case study approach. “There’s no perfect answer, and it was remarkably different from my engineering upbringing, where it revolved around precision or a